

What, in Sonic Terms, Might Characterise the Opposite of Intimacy?

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Mediating Intimacy: Space and Intersubjectivity in Recorded Music & Sound

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Introduction

"If a tree falls in the forest and no one is there to hear it, does it make a sound?"

This well-known thought experiment is often posed to initiate discussions surrounding reality and observation (Eidsheim, 2015, 1) but in the present context it initiates an interesting dialogue surrounding the true nature of sound and its affective power. Sonic intimacy can be defined by action and interaction (Horrigan, 2022), and through this sound becomes touch. The opposite of such a concept must be a lack of interaction, and therefore silence. However, an answer to this question requires an understanding of the relationship between sound, silence, and touch.

Intimacy is mediated in various ways, with or without physical proximity, and the clear rival to intimacy is distance. However, distance is passive; it is defined as the *absence* of intimacy. Sound's phantom presence in every aspect of modern life challenges the assumption that distance is the opposite of sonic intimacy — achieving distance from sound is close to impossible. However, the active use of sound to manipulate or conjure negative responses — oppression, interruption or invasion — opens the floor to explore the exploitation of sound as an antagonistic force, equally as affective as intimate sound but working to break connections rather than cultivate them. The characterisation of the *opposite* intimacy must then be an active force pushing against it, trying to destroy it.

This essay proposes a concept I call "Sonic Anti-Intimacy": a semantically rich term inspired by the concept of the "anti-hero". In the traditional sense, an anti-hero is an archetype who has the same objectives as the hero but has an antagonal undertone. Sonic

anti-intimacy stands as a conceptual cousin to the anti-hero, emerging from systems of mediation that stimulate closeness but foster detachment, dominance, and isolation instead.

By using sound as an affective force, both intimacy and its opposite create affective environments, but they serve different purposes. My central claim in this essay is that sonic anti-intimacy is a carefully designed concept built through technologies of sound that mask detachment behind feigned proximity. Like a wolf in sheep's clothing, sonic anti-intimacy has made its way into modern society unnoticed, embedding itself in the sonic and social fabrics of our world.

Point 1: Theoretical Frameworks — Defining Sonic Anti-Intimacy

1.1 Sonic Anti-Intimacy

To understand how anti-intimacy functions, we must first look at how intimacy is constructed and, more importantly, how it can be broken down. Rather than relying on physical proximity, I propose that sonic intimacy relies on the affective relationship between sound and listener. This affective exchange is not neutral: it operates within a complex web of power. Piekut's formulation of Actor-Network Theory (hereafter ANT) helps reveal this web by flattening the hierarchy of power when looking at sonic networks, positing a particular understanding of agency that takes the simple idea of sonic intimacy and turns it into a question of how sound operates and interacts with both the listener and the emitter. For example, the act of whispering holds different meanings depending on the environment surrounding it; "change the network, and you change the actor" (Piekut, 2014, 194). Piekut's theorisation of ANT is essential when looking at the impact of recorded sound on our relationship with intimacy. The dialogue between person and sound becomes targeted

in any scenario, regardless of the environment. By removing the influence of the outside world to create an enclosed sonic environment, recorded music is always loaded with purpose. ANT allows us to see how our conscious manipulations of sound contribute to affective atmospheres, thus revealing the agency that it has always possessed, recognising that sound has always been a part of the machinery of social power and control (Attali, 1985, 6).

This framework removes sound from its societal placement as a byproduct of human intention and positions it as a powerful force in shaping how intimacy is formed and broken. With the power of technological mediation, sound becomes easily malleable and weaponised. I propose three mechanisms through which sonic anti-intimacy emerges: isolation, dominance, and detachment. Each mechanism disrupts a different aspect of affective connection: isolation strangles closeness, dominance overrides autonomy, and detachment erases empathy. These mechanisms characterise anti-intimacy as a warped mirror image of Sonic intimacy; if intimacy can be heard, then anti-intimacy must also be listened for, whether within a cacophony of sound or the breaks between silences.

1.1.1 Sonic Isolation

Sonic isolation refers to the physical and psychological distance that certain manipulations of sound can create, as discussed in Kahn's study on silence (1997). At the core of sonic anti-intimacy is the forced separation, through sound, of people from each other. The rise of personal audio technologies, from the Walkman to noise-cancelling headphones, has recentred sonic environments around individualism. Michael Bull traces the evolution of our modern mediated society through the birth of the Apple iPod (2007), arguing that the development of mediated sound has contributed to the erasure of spaces

that we move through, instead living and moving within the architectures that we build within our own minds. Urban experience has become increasingly more isolated, becoming "non-spaces" (Bull, 2007). This concept, developed by Bull, theorises the power that iPods had over our inherent social nature, negatively affecting the way in which time and space unfold in the world beyond our own.

Shuhei Hosokawa adds depth to our discussion on mediated isolation, arguing that the privatisation of shared space through mediated listening has characterised sound as a shield rather than a bridge. Sonic anti-intimacy is thus not the absence of sound but the collapse of shared listening. With the constant evolution of recording techniques, emotional nuances are still present within audio files. Jonathan Sterne argues that compression reduces dynamic range and flattens emotional nuance, but with the rise of mediated forms of close listening through ASMR, sonic isolation becomes more accessible and attractive. Marc Augé's "ethnography of solitude" (1995) expands as we venture into the world of mediated sound; the desire for solitude is easily satiated through mediated relationships, severing physical connection to hold space for mediated sonic relationships. To foster a community through shared listening, technology has slowly stripped us of our collective voice and replaced them with the voices we hear in our heads.

1.1.2 Sonic Dominance

Sonic dominance can be characterised as the exploitation of vulnerability. While sonic intimacy requires attention and vulnerability to thrive (Eidsheim, 2015; Pettman

2017), sonic dominance victimises and oppresses through means of both hard and soft control.

Dominance creates a specific affective relationship between the two subjects, where the balance is overwhelmingly in favour of the former. Sonically, dominance requires presence to be enacted, which is achieved through technological mediation. This mediated presence is essential for virtual assistants (hereafter VAs) such as Siri and Alexa, who provide help and mask their monitored and controlled presence behind a calming female voice, promoting gender stereotypes and heightening the sense of comfort and aid surrounding them (Nass, 1997). By presenting a false sense of connection, VAs create a narrative that what we communicate with them remains between the two parties. We are lured into a form of sonic intimacy shared between two voices, but the companies behind VAs employ people to analyse the content of the users' voice interactions, complicating the value of privacy (Kudina *et al*, 2021). We remain at the will of mediated sonic dominance because of our lack of knowledge surrounding such technology, and breaking out of the cycle is almost impossible.

By virtue of sound's intangible nature, sonic dominance pervades daily life, the most alarming being the subtle yet firm hold of the background music industry on society. There is a difference between attention and submission; whilst sonic intimacy requires attention in willing connections, sonic dominance seeks submission, overwhelming and conditioning its subjects. The most poignant example of music's soft control is background music in shopping malls. We do not have a choice of what we listen to, but the music dictates our tempo, mood, and direction in certain spaces (MacLeod, 1979). Muzak's grip on societal

patterns is also reflected in other aspects of conditioning, including alarms, school bells, and train announcements. These sounds dictate our movements, acting as hard forms of control. These sounds have infiltrated our modern society and, borrowing from Bernie Krause's acoustic niche hypothesis, have turned our natural ecosystems into "hi-fi" soundscapes (Krause, 1993). Krause's theory suggests that ecosystems are as vulnerable to noise pollution as chemical pollution – the point of danger for either is when they exceed the tolerances of adaption and resilience (Horrigan, 2022, 225).

1.1.3 Sonic Detachment

Sonic detachment bears similarities to sonic isolation; anti-intimacy embodies the relationships that are unwillingly made through sound, or those relationships that have been severed by it. Sound draws people's attention, asking for time and vulnerability. However, in a modern society overrun by company jingles, background music, and the occasional heckler on the streets, sound is no longer listened to, and it is barely even heard. Sound's affective power is nullified by sonic anti-intimacy's efforts to sever the connection between listener and emitter. The absence of sound would then mean the absence of intimacy, following this logic. However, sonic anti-intimacy is defined through the affective power of silence as a social construct. Sonic detachment draws upon the works of Kahn and Horrigan to rationalise the increasing threat of sound as a weapon, turning to the idea of action and reaction to understand how the over dilution of sound in our modern world, and the choice to ignore it, has driven us further away from sound. Although he writes about the dawn of the iPod, Bull taps into the very danger of mediated sound and its success in pulling people apart. People have slowly become subject to the demands of the phone (Bull, 2007, 8). The

background music industry was born out of the need to fill the silences of the perceived oppressive rhythms of working life, carefully curating music that would increase productivity and efficiency, but not to be listened to tentatively (MacLeod, 1979). However, as the 21st century continues to unfold and sound technology only improves, people become more detached from life beyond the walls of their minds, or the distance between their headphones.

Sonic detachment is very similar to sonic isolation; however, this mechanism is characterised by the immunity we build against sound, whereas sonic isolation turns inwards, looking at how sound traps us within ourselves. Bauman (2003) proposes that "silence equals exclusion", and in the case of sonic detachment, silence is not the absence of sound, but rather the overexposure of sound and the subsequent failure, and lack of desire, to decipher what we here, thus remaining detached from our sonic environment.

Point 2. "Moosak" & False Closeness

The title of this section is taken from R Murray Schaefer, who defined "Moosak" as a generic term for all programmed musics (Schaefer, 1977, 98); the more commonly used term "Muzak" refers only to the music produced by the Muzak Corporation. Muzak was among many companies involved in programmed music, the biggest being 3M, who accounts for around 25% of the programmed music business, as explored in MacLeod's seminal study on Muzak's influence on industry in the 1970s (MacLeod, 1979, 19). Programmed music is a clear manifestation of sonic anti-intimacy through its success in controlling the idea of individualism. Jones and Schumacher's definition of power states that it is "exercised on the minds and bodies of the individual through the regulation of

conscience and feelings" (Jones & Schumacher, 1992, 184). This definition builds upon Foucault's definition of power as operating directly on the body and its physiological processes with the aims of forging a "docile body" – one that can be "subjected, used, transformed, and improved" (Foucault, 1979, 136). Our nuanced understanding of power perfectly translates into our discussion of programmed music; although music is an intangible object, its influence inserts it as a dominant actor within social and cultural networks.

Muzak is curated to perform intimacy and mask its bloated power behind a veil of acoustic smoothness. MacLeod dissects the process behind Muzak, detailing a rigorous algorithm that judges arrangements according to four musical factors: tempo, rhythm, instrumentation, and orchestra size. Songs are rated according to these factors, arriving at a number called the Stimulus Quotient (MacLeod, 1979). This highly strategic approach to music curation removes the humanity from music, defining muzak as something to be heard, curated to separate the soul from the body and operate efficiently. What defines the sound of muzak is affective smoothness; the arrangements are void of musical subjectivity, mimicking intimacy through soft instrumentation; however, this false pretence covers muzak's true intention to pacify, forcing us to be docile and to keep consuming. This algorithm has proven successful in the retail industry; studies have shown that for every minute a customer spends in a retail store, he or she will spend approximately one dollar. with music in the store, the customer will remain in the store an average of three minutes longer (MacLeod, 1979).

The ability to manipulate and regulate patterns of consumption is at the forefront of muzak's purpose; there is no such thing as a completely neutral buying or working atmosphere. Programmed music is part of a multitude of factors that influence us subconsciously, including architectural design, colour and lighting. Programmed music operates within our subconscious; its success lies in how little we notice it. MacLeod conducted a study at Wesleyan University where he conducted a three-week course involving programmed music installations provided by multiple programmed music firms. He emphasises subconscious listening, understanding that many participants did not register the music they heard during this course. The common response from students was either "what music?" or "I don't listen to it" when asked to comment on the music they heard (1979, 25). MacLeod's study adds nuance to our understanding of the effect of programmed music on the everyday consumer, revealing how it affects only our subconscious mind.

Muzak is present without being relational, performing intimacy without honesty. Sonic dominance is present in the lack of connection between body and sound – muzak forces us to disconnect from ourselves and exist within the system it provides for us. Horrigan puts forth the idea that "action implies interaction" (Horrigan, 2022), and this remains true across both positive and negative contexts; the affective power that muzak holds prescribes our interaction with it, thus impacting how we act in specific environments.

While MacLeod and Jones & Schumacher theorise the power of Muzak in the 20th century, it is important to map Muzak's development into the modern day, primarily through algorithmically curated playlists. Pushing past the dawn of controlled environments in the 1970s, mediated listening has continuously contributed to the legacy of Muzak by masking pacification with personalisation. Spotify's curated playlists for specific moods, most commonly for studying or sleeping, mimic the same sentiments presented in Muzak: curate playlists that would stimulate a specific physical and psychological response. Paul Allen Anderson proposed the term "Neo-muzak" to describe certain streaming platforms, describing their services as "personal care products for affect management and mood elevation" (Anderson, 2015, 811). Muzak laid the foundation for emotional manipulation through music, but platforms like Spotify exploited the power of mediated listening to micromanage these moods and affect how people behave and experience the world around them. This serves as a modern manifestation of sonic dominance – Spotify, and other neo-muzak companies, provide services with the aim of soft control. Hiding behind the disguise of agency and freedom, Spotify's curated playlists push specific music, either curated by humans or an algorithm (2015, 813) to continue the disconnect between music and people.

Point 3: Silence as Dominance, Not Absence

Silence, often romanticised in film and music, is perceived as emotionally charged — full of tension and meaning because of its fragility. One utterance can break the silence and negate all its affective power. Framing silence in this way makes it a passive state however, there is a distinction between silence and *being silenced*. Kahn draws upon this understanding of silence not only as an absence, but, in some contexts, the oversaturation of

sound. He writes that "just as silence against silence could produce music, noise against noise could produce silence" (Kahn, 1997, 577), framing the relentless sonic layering of our modern world as a form of isolation; noise is so constant that it ceases to exist. The erosion of sound and silence blurs their difference, trapping the listener in isolation.

This frames silence not as a meditative stillness, but as an erasure. When sound no longer registers as communication it loses its depth and becomes indistinct. Kahn's observation is coloured by the context of the late 20th century media landscape, and since then, noisy silence has become a greater threat to society because of the growing digital world. With the evolution from Muzak to car radios, lo-fi YouTube playlists, and endless urban noise, Jones and Schumacher's assertion that power is exercised through "the regulation of consciousness and feeling" (1992) becomes more relevant than ever, implicating sound in systems of soft control. Building on Kahn's paradox, Jones and Schumacher present a sinister idea that sound has been remodelled into a means for control; they reveal how even silence can be weaponised and used to distract, numb, or dominate.

Sonic anti-intimacy is at play here through the active manipulation of sound for mass control. With the development of headset technology, and the rapid growth of social media platforms and music streaming services, sonic isolation has become an increasingly pressing issue. Attali comments that "any theory of power today must include a theory of the localisation of noise and its endowment with form" (Attali, 1985, 6). Through our efforts to shape, study, and use noise, we have harnessed a power source that acts covertly. Attali's assertion can be placed in dialogue with Kahn's paradox — the manufacturing of noise into music for control has also become the manipulation of noise for the purpose to

dominate and isolate. Attali also shares space with Jones and Schumacher, who understand power as being truly attained through controlling the psyche. Each of these theories play with the idea of noise as an affective actor in social networks, looking into the ways in which noise becomes an active disruption of the ability to connect.

"One of the central effects of Cage's battery of silencing techniques was a silencing of the social" (Khan, 1997, 580). Kahn's reading reveals an engineered silence that sterilises the social; while silence can be perceived as an intimate exchange, Cage inverts it, muting relational fabrics rather than honouring them. Touching upon Cage's infamous composition, 4'33", Kahn rationalises with Cage's philosophical gesture of the performativity of silence, and its redundancy in such a sonically active world. By making silence a type of sound, "actual silence was merely a state of inaudibility, and everything known before as silence became nothing but small sounds contingent upon amplification" (Kahn, 1997, 583). Understanding silence through this lens pushes the idea that silence is no longer the absence of sound but the absence of connection. Silence is an actor, equal in affect to noise, that operates within many networks; its power to manipulate emotion, either creating or destroying relationships, marks it as a key concept in understanding sonic anti-intimacy. Kahn defines the idea of "Cagean silence" as an active force — 4'33" transposed the performance onto the audience members through the act of silencing the performer. This is an example of the transmission of power through sound, and ultimately the presence of sonic anti-intimacy in Cage's piece. The active silencing of the performer shifts the balance within the concert hall, and interrupts the connection built between the performer

and audience, creating an atmosphere that disrupts rather than nurtures. By letting environmental sounds fill the absence of musical sound in 4'33" (Kahn, 1997, 562), Cage attempts to reveal the relentlessly active world we live in and expose the extent to which we are disconnected from the noise in which we exist.

The inversion of silence from being the absence of sound to the absence of connection solidifies the idea of sonic anti-intimacy as a tool for control. By bridging Kahn's paradox with theories put forth by Attali, Jones and Schumacher, we construct an understanding of sonic anti-intimacy as an active prevention of connection. We see the impact of noisy silence in every aspect of modern life, and sonic detachment sits at the core of it. We live in a world where silence can be distorted to sever connections; sonic anti-intimacy stands as the antipode of intimacy, forcing presence into absence and sound into isolation.

Conclusion

We return to our opening thought: "If a tree falls in the forest and no one is there to hear it, does it make a sound?" In our exploration, the question has been inverted; if sound is ever-present but no longer connects, what is the source of its meaning? This essay has argued that the opposite of sonic intimacy is not distance or silence in the passive form, but the active engineering of disconnection through sound itself – sonic anti-intimacy.

Sound technology has assumed a more sinister undertone through the mechanisms of isolation, dominance and detachment, destroying relationships rather than cultivating them. Personal listening devices create worlds within rather than between people. Muzak and neo-muzak operate as weapons of consumption, snaking through public space behind

a mask of mood elevation; the affective disposition of curated background music breaks down the connection between sound and mind through algorithmic listening rather than organic interest. Even silence has become a saturated signal, obscuring meaning instead of building trust.

These sonic tactics serve as ideological instruments, embedded in infrastructures of surveillance, capitalism, and soft control. If sonic intimacy is touch without the body, then sonic anti-intimacy is presence without connection – an active corruption. In placing Attali's noise, Kahn's silence, and Pettman's intimacy in dialogue, we have shown that sound serves as an actor in affective networks, manipulating the conditions under which feelings become possible. To hear is no longer enough. We must learn to listen again, for presence as well as for sound.

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